



With her defiant stance over bus seating in Montgomery, Alabama, in 1955, Rosa Parks began an unstoppable movement toward equal rights and the end of segregation.

Supreme Court agreed, too, with Chief Justice Earl Warren ruling in 1954 that “in the field of public education the doctrine of ‘separate but equal’ has no place,” as segregated schools are “inherently unequal.” However, it would take decades for the decision to be fully implemented. Meanwhile, there was another challenge to segregation.

Rosa Parks

On December 1, 1955, Rosa Parks, a woman of mixed heritage in Montgomery, Alabama, quietly refused the bus driver’s insistence that she give up her seat in the “mixed” middle section of the bus she was traveling on. Like Plessy 63 years earlier, she was arrested, but this time there was resistance in the form of public protests. On the day of her trial, black civil rights activists led by pastor Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. called for a boycott of all the buses in Montgomery. The day’s boycott turned into one of

the longest and most determined civil rights actions the US has seen. The boycott went on for 381 days, during which 90 percent of black people refused to travel on the buses. It proved highly effective and ended only when the Supreme Court ruled that segregation on buses was illegal.

White backlash

The court ruling triggered a vicious reaction, with someone firing a shotgun through Martin Luther King Jr.’s door; bombings at black churches; and a young black man, Willie Edwards, being killed by the Ku Klux Klan (a white supremacist hate group) for dating a white woman. Black people soon returned to riding separately on the buses.

To reduce tension, President Dwight D. Eisenhower put a new Civil Rights Act in place in 1957, enabling the prosecution of anyone who tried to stop someone voting. However, segregation was still an ugly fact. In 1960, four students in Greensboro, North Carolina, staged a sit-in at the Woolworth’s lunch counter where they had been refused service because only white people could sit at the bar. Soon,

People always said that I didn’t give up my seat because I was tired, but that isn’t true ... No, the only tired I was, was tired of giving in.

Rosa Parks

Rosa Parks: My Story, 1992

student sit-ins were being staged across the South. Protesters were often beaten and jailed, but they persisted until Woolworth’s relented and the segregated counters ended.

In October 1960, Martin Luther King Jr. had been arrested in Atlanta, Georgia, for leading one such civil rights sit-in at a lunch counter. Presidential candidate John F. Kennedy offered his support to King and assisted with his release. Grateful for this display at a difficult moment, King endorsed Kennedy for president, and as a

American Indian civil rights

Unlike black people, American Indians sought to limit the damage of discrimination not by inclusion but by the protection of tribal lands. The brutal 1830 Removals Act had robbed them of much, but there was a fraction left to provide some homeland. There was tension within the civil rights movement in the 1950s and 1960s between black people, who were campaigning for recognition in the Constitution, and American Indians who thought this was a

naive hope. The Indian Civil Rights Act (ICRA) of 1968 was intended by Congress to recognize that the policy of assimilation had been a failure. But not all American Indians were happy with the bill. By guaranteeing the constitutional rights of individuals, the ICRA allowed them to challenge tribal governments. Various US administrations have since shifted gradually toward recognizing tribal sovereignty, but it remains a thorny issue.